

Running the Website: the Complete Reference

This manual is for whoever runs the Holiday Project website — today's coordinator or the person who takes over someday. It assumes you have never seen the site before, and it covers every screen, every button, and the rhythm of a season.

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1. What this program is

The Grant County Holiday Project is an all-volunteer program, more than thirty years old, that provides food, gifts, and clothing to 300–400 low-income families and elderly neighbors across Grant County, Wisconsin each December. It partners with Tri-State Toys for Tots (Dubuque, IA). It is not government-run: the county lets the project use its tax-exempt status, all finances and receipts run through the county's financial department, and the county audits the program yearly.

Families apply from the season's opening day into November — the coordinator chooses when to open (historically October 1; in 2026, September 20, because adoptions begin early) — online through the website, or on a paper form that gets typed into the website so everything lives in one list. The Apply page offers two applications, matching the program's two paper forms: the full **Family Household** application (children under 18) and a short **Elderly/Disabled Household** application (over 65, or receiving Social Security or SSI — no sizes or gift questions; these households get mailed cards). The applicant's choice sets the household type, which the coordinator can always correct in Edit details. The coordinator reviews each application, approves or denies it, and runs packing and distribution by town in December. Elderly and disabled households are served separately: they receive gift and food cards **by mail** and never go through packing or pickup.

Applicants "pay it forward": each application includes good deeds done for others in the community. It is part of eligibility, and it is checked by a person — never by the software.

2. Getting access

1. The website is grantcountyholidayproject.org. The coordinator's workspace — "the admin" — is at grantcountyholidayproject.org/admin.
2. There is no password. You type your email address, press **Email me a sign-in link**, and click the link in the email it sends you. Links work for 15 minutes and only once; you stay signed in about 30 days.
3. **Your email address must be on the admin list first.** Adding or removing an authorized email is a developer task (section 8) — it is the very first thing a new coordinator arranges.

First week suggestion: sign in while applications are closed, open every screen in the green menu with this manual beside you, and enter one clearly-marked TEST paper application (last name "TEST") to practice approving, printing, and deleting. Delete it when you're done — deletes ask for confirmation and offer an Undo.

3. The shape of a season

When	What you do on the website
September	Freshen the home page on This year's news (dates, the special gifts list); set this year's Pickup schedule ; upload the new blank paper application PDFs (Family and Elderly/Disabled).
Opening day (you choose)	Press Open applications on the admin Home screen when your season begins — historically October 1; in 2026, September 20, because adoptions start early. Post the date in This year's news beforehand. Donations begin October 1.
Application season	Review applications as they arrive; type in paper applications; verify income and the good deeds by hand (the website does no eligibility math); approve or deny (approving assigns the pickup number automatically); mark Thanksgiving cards as you give them — the first 30 applicants get one, and the list counts them for you; adopt out ~50-60 families to organizations and adoptive sponsors (marked on each application — they leave the packing flow and land on the Adoptions page); keep notes on each application.
Packing	Work town by town: pick the town in the Show town dropdown, print the list, the packing slips for the volunteers, and the pick up notices to mail. They are two different papers. The PACKING slip stays at the site and tells volunteers what goes in each family's boxes — sizes, doll choice, and a "Gifts to pack" column, which prints whatever is in each person's "Gifts / toys wanted" boxes: the coordinator edits those first under Edit household members (swapping anything the project is out of), so the slip is the final pack list. The PICK UP notice is mailed to the family — a copy of the coordinator's paper form: name, ID# (their pickup number), pickup day, and the location rules only, three to a page with dashed cut lines.
~10 days before pickup	Packing slips carry each family's pickup date automatically if you've matched towns to days (section 6.6). Elderly & disabled: print the mailed list with addresses, send their gift and food cards, and record them in each family's Cards given box.
Distribution days	Give each day's distributors the Excel download for their town — it lists who's coming, in pickup-number order, with the Special Gift column for the first-come extra-gifts table.

End of project	Serve the stragglers (their own list and 2400-series numbers). Press Close applications . The season's records stay in the website for the county audit.
Anytime	Late applications after a town is packed: mark them Straggler on their application page.

4. The pickup-number system

Every approved household gets a pickup number. The number follows the family everywhere: the lists, the packing slips, the Excel — and it is how boxes are matched to families. Each town owns a block of one hundred numbers; the first approved household from a town gets the base number itself, the next gets base + 1, and so on. **Approving an application assigns the next number automatically.** Numbers are never reused within a season, even if an application is deleted.

Block	Belongs to	Block	Belongs to
100s	Blue River	1300s	Glen Haven
200s	Muscoda	1400s	Patch Grove
300s	Cuba City	1500s	Platteville
400s	Dickeyville	1600s	Fennimore
500s	Hazel Green	1700s	Livingston
600s	Kieler	1800s	Montfort
700s	Potosi	1900s	Mt. Hope
800s	Lancaster	2000s	Stitzer
900s	Bagley	2100s	Boscobel
1000s	Beetown	2200s	Woodman
1100s	Bloomington	2300s	Prairie du Chien
1200s	Cassville	2400s	Stragglers (late, after their town packed)
2500s	Elderly & disabled — mailed their cards, never packed, never on packing slips		

Every number can be changed by hand in the **Pickup number** box on the application page — for reconciling with paper records, or for any special case that needs a number outside the blocks. The website only enforces one rule: no two households ever share a number. If a town's hundred numbers ever run out, the website says so plainly and you type numbers in yourself.

5. What the software decides — and what you decide

The website never decides eligibility and never denies anyone automatically. Every approval and every denial is a human decision. This is a founding rule of the site, not an accident.

The software does: assign pickup numbers by block; record when applications arrive and when you decide; display what each family reported — income, jobs, household, good deed — exactly as they gave it; keep your card tallies (Thanksgiving, food, gift) and count Thanksgiving cards toward 30; keep a plain-English

History of every change to every application (what changed, when, by whom) plus each application exactly as first submitted; point out possible duplicates (two applications with the same name and address) for you to compare; run the adoption workflow only for families who said Yes to sharing (checked again at the moment of saving); add up the season's numbers on the **Season summary** page; keep everything for the audit.

You decide — all of it: whether income fits the program's limits (the website does *no* income math and shows *no* eligibility flags — the coordinator compares reported income against the 200%-of-poverty chart by hand, knowing families sometimes under-report or forget income); whether the pay-it-forward requirement is met; whether the household type is right (elderly and disabled mean age 65+, or found disabled by Social Security — and living in Grant County); approvals, denials, stragglers, and every number you choose to change.

6. Every screen, in detail

The green menu on every admin page: **Home** · **Applications this year** · **This year's news** · **Pickup schedule** · **Season summary** · **Adoptions** · **Paper application** · **Donors** · **Messages**. Every screen has a Back link, and **View the website** shows what families see.

6.1 Home

- Shows whether applications are **OPEN or CLOSED**, with one button to switch (asks "are you sure" first). While closed, families see a kind message pointing to the phone line and the paper form.
- Cards linking to every other screen, and the count of unread messages.

6.2 Applications this year

- **Tabs:** To review · Approved · Denied · All. **Search by name.** A **year** control looks back at past seasons (past seasons stay stored for the audit). The list always opens on the season you're actually working — in January it stays on the season you're wrapping up, and only moves to the new year once its first application arrives.
- **Show town dropdown:** All towns · each town · Elderly & disabled (mailed) · Stragglers · Adopted. A town view lists that town's applications in pickup-number order — the distributor list, and the answer when a school asks who in their town is served. The mailed view adds addresses (your mail list). The Stragglers view is the late list, by itself. The chosen view follows you through tabs, search, printing, and the Excel download.
- **Buttons:** **Enter a paper application** (6.4), **Print this list**, **Print packing slips**, **Download list for Excel**, **Download everything (backup)**. The print buttons and both downloads follow the current Show-town view — pick a town (or Stragglers) first to print just that stack.
- **Print pickup slips to mail:** next to Print packing slips — the mailed Pick Up Notices, a faithful copy of the coordinator's paper form (name, ID#, pickup day, location rules; NO household details — it travels in the mail). Three per page with dashed cut lines; follows the current Show-town view like every print button. Stragglers automatically show the straggler pickup day. Each application page also has its own **Print pickup slip** button next to Print packing slip, for late approvals and one-off reprints. A blank date line means the family's town isn't matched to a day yet (section 6.6).
- **Also on this screen:** a running "*Thanksgiving cards: X of 30 given*" count for the season, and a warning when a town has used 90 of its 100 numbers.
- **Mailing labels:** in the Elderly & disabled (mailed) view, a **Print mailing labels** button prints Christmas-card envelope labels (Avery 30-per-sheet, 1in x 2 5/8in): name, address, "{Town}, WI". Approved, non-adopted mailed households only. A long address is trimmed to keep the sheet aligned — the on-screen preview shows exactly what prints, so glance before printing.
- **"65+ in household" badge:** a family-typed application containing a member aged 65 or older gets a gold badge (and a note on its page) — the cue to consider removing that person under Edit household members and entering a separate Elderly/Disabled application so they get their own Christmas card. Nothing happens automatically.
- **"Disabled person in household" badge:** the same idea for a family-typed application containing a member marked permanently disabled — gold badge, plus a note on its page naming them. Split them onto their own card application if they qualify alone; a disabled parent with children under 18 stays on the family application (regular gifts, not cards — the sorting rule below). Nothing happens automatically.
- **How applications sort themselves (Sherlyn's rule, 2026-07-30):** a household with any child under 18 always arrives typed *Family*, even if a parent or member is disabled. Only childless

households sort to Elderly/Disabled (disabled member → Disabled; first person 65+ → Elderly). The Elderly/Disabled online form sets the type from the applicant's own answer. You can always correct the type in Edit details — the pickup number moves blocks when you do.

- **"May be a duplicate" badge:** when two applications in the season share the same last name and address (a family applying online and on paper, say), both rows get a quiet gold badge. It is a nudge to compare, never a judgment — the website only matches exact name-and-address pairs, and blank addresses never match.
- **The main Excel download** is the coordinator's working sheet, column for column: *tNo* (pickup number), the applicant, address, *Special Gift* (each person's gift requests plus any doll choices), *adopted*, *Thanksgiving*, *Food Card/Cert.* and its amount, *Gift Cards* and their amount, and the number in the household.
- **The backup download** ("Download everything") carries the full record: status, decided and applied dates, phone, email, household type, every household member with sizes and doll choices, years of help, bedding, income as reported, jobs, the card tallies, the parentage note, your private notes, and whether the application came online or on paper. Use it before purging anything, for the audit, and for handover.

6.3 One application (click any name)

- **Top:** when it was applied (date and time) and whether it was entered from paper.
- **Household & People:** everyone listed with relationship to the parent, age, sex, disabled / lives-here-part-time marks, clothing sizes (pants, shirt, underwear, socks, diapers, shoe, coat), gift requests, and each child's **doll choice** (White doll / Non-White doll / no doll). A "which children belong to whom" note for blended families.
- **Income:** jobs (employer, wage, hours) and benefits (Food Share, Social Security, SSI, child support, unemployment, other), shown exactly as the family reported them. **The website does no eligibility math** — comparing income to the poverty chart is the coordinator's hand-check, remembering that families sometimes under-report or forget income.
- **Good deed:** the pay-it-forward report.
- **Editing:** **Edit application**, **Edit people**, and **Edit jobs** change anything the family got wrong or that you verified differently.
- **Possible duplicate note:** if another application this season has the same last name and address, a note appears above the decision buttons naming it — including whether it is already approved and its pickup number — with a link to compare. The website never merges or blocks anything; you decide which one stands (delete the extra with Undo available, as always).
- **Decision:** **Approve and email them** / **Approve without email** / **Deny and email them** / **Deny without email**. Approving assigns the pickup number from the household's block; the page then shows "Approved on {date, time}." The approval email matches the household: family households get the pickup-slip email; Elderly/Disabled households get the Christmas-card email ("a Christmas card containing a food and a gift card... the second week in December"). If the application has **no email address** (email is optional on the Elderly/Disabled form and on paper entry), the two "email them" buttons don't appear — a note explains there's nothing to email, and **Approve without email** takes the green style. Mail the household a note instead if they should be told; the email wording below is ready to copy. Below: the **Pickup number** box (change or clear any number by hand) and the **Straggler** checkbox (ALWAYS the coordinator's manual call — the software never sets it; for applications too late for their town's packing, or too close to it for a mailed slip to arrive → 2400s, gifts near the end). Below those, family households get the **Pickup day for this family** dropdown — "Their town's day (the usual)" or any specific day, for the big towns that pick up across more than one day. The choice wins over the town match and the straggler day; History records it.
- **What the decision emails say, word for word** (each begins "Hello {first name}," and ends with the message line, 608-723-2136 ext 1194; the wording lives in `src/lib/email/render.ts`):
 - *Family approved* — subject "Your Holiday Project application was approved": "Good news - your Grant County Holiday Project application has been approved. Watch your mail and email for

your pickup slip, which will have your pickup date in December. Please bring your pickup slip with you."

- *Elderly/Disabled approved* — subject "Your Holiday Project Elderly/Disabled application was approved": "You have been found eligible for the Grant County Holiday Project Elderly/Disabled program. Your gifts are a Christmas card containing a food and a gift card. You should receive the card the second week in December."
- *Denied* — subject "An update on your Holiday Project application": "Thank you for applying to the Grant County Holiday Project. After review, we are not able to approve your application this season. Applications are denied for one of the following reasons: Excess income · No children under 18 living in the household · Receiving benefits from another program · Someone else has already applied for the children. We know this is hard to hear. If you have questions... we are glad to talk with you." (All four reasons are always listed, never the specific one — the coordinator's long-standing practice; callers get the details.)
- **Adoption (approved applications only):** when the family answered Yes to sharing with a sponsor, mark them adopted — who adopted them (required), contact person, phone, mailing address — with **Mark adopted and email them** / **without email** (the family's email says: no pickup slip in December; the adoptive organization or community family will contact you by December 7th to set up pickup dates and times; keep your phone working; everything kept confidential). **Timing matters and is built in:** approve families normally at review — adoption request forms come back from adopters in October or later, so mark a family adopted whenever the match is made; the adoption email corrects the approval email's pickup-slip promise. To send the adopter their family's details, the family's own **Print packing slip for the adopter** button keeps working after marking (print, or print-to-PDF and email it) — the packers' pile never includes adopted families. They get an Adopted tag on the list and appear on the Adoptions page. Details stay editable; **Remove adoption mark** undoes it (and stays available even if consent is later withdrawn). If the family said No to sharing, the section shows a note instead — change their answer in Edit details first. The website re-checks the consent answer at the moment of saving, every time.
- **Packing note (prints for the packers):** a small box whose text prints on this family's packing slip as "Note for packers:" — for guidance volunteers need, like choosing toys suited to a child with special needs. Deliberately volunteer-visible; keep anything private in Notes below instead.
- **Cards given (only you see this):** check off the **Thanksgiving card** (the first 30 applicants get one; the applications list counts them for you), **food card or certificate** with its amount, and **gift cards** with their amount. Nothing is automatic — it is the coordinator's record, and it flows into the Excel columns.
- **What the cards are (Sherlyn's practice, 2026):** the food card pays for the household's Christmas meal. Family households get up to about **\$100**, scaled to the size of the family — and their requested gifts besides, so the adults have gifts under the tree like the kids. An elderly/disabled household of one gets about **\$25**. Elderly/disabled households receive their food and gift cards

mailed inside their Christmas card — the whole point of the mailed program is that they never have to come to the site in the winter cold. Amounts are the coordinator's yearly judgment, not a rule the software enforces.

- **Notes (only you see this):** private space for your eligibility notes and anything from paper with no field (has a car, Box number). Never shown to families.
- **Print packing slip** for this one family (a late approval prints from its own page — nothing else reprinted; mailed households show a plain note instead of a print button); **Delete** (asks first, offers Undo right after; a missed Undo is fine — deletes are never physical: every removed application waits in the **Removed applications** list at the bottom of the applications page, with a **Put it back** button, for as long as the season exists).
- **History (only you see this):** at the bottom of the page, every change to the application in plain English — "Social Security (monthly) changed from \$800 to \$650" — with the date, time, and who made it (the family's own submission shows as "the family"). Read-only; nothing ever edits or deletes it. A "**See the application as first submitted**" link opens the application exactly as it originally arrived, frozen and printable — the before-and-after pair the county audit can rely on. Applications from before July 2026 start with an empty history.

6.4 Enter a paper application

- The same form families use, for typing in mailed or handed-in paper applications. Only the **name and town are required** — leave anything blank that is blank on the paper (incomplete applications need a record too, so denials are on file). Enter 0 for a wage or age the paper doesn't give. Each person's card includes the **doll choice** (No doll / White doll / Non-White doll) — copy it straight from the paper.
- Extras: **date received** (defaults to today), the **pickup number** if one is already written on the paper, the household type, and your private notes right on the form.
- Nothing is emailed to the family from this screen, and it works even while applications are closed (stragglers arrive late by definition).

6.5 This year's news

- The blocks of text families read on the public home page — the news, the special gifts list, and the key dates. Each block has a title and its text; type in the boxes and press **Save** — the public page updates immediately, no waiting.
- Add a new block, move blocks up or down to reorder them, and delete with Undo. The special gifts list is edited here all season long as items are claimed.

6.6 Pickup schedule

- **Wording:** the title, intro, and footer families see on the public Pickup Schedule page.
- **Pickup days:** add, edit, reorder, and delete days (with Undo).
- **Which day does each town pick up?** Match towns (and Stragglers) to days, and every printed packing slip AND mailed pick up notice fills in its family's date automatically. Leave a town on "Not set" and its slips print with a blank date to hand-write — your choice, town by town. Do this matching before printing pick up notices, or their date line prints blank.
- **Big towns across more than one day (Boscobel, Platteville):** create each session as its own day here (say "Platteville — Tuesday Dec. 16th, 11–2:30" and "Platteville — Wednesday Dec. 17th, 4–7"), match the town to one of them as the usual, then use the **Pickup day for this family** dropdown on any application to put that family on the other day. The per-family choice always wins — over the town match and over the straggler day — and both slips follow it.

6.7 Season summary

- The year's numbers on one printable page, computed live from the applications list: applications received (online, from paper, imported), families served, still to review, denied, people in served households, families by town in pickup-number order (with the Stragglers and Elderly & disabled rows), and the card tallies — Thanksgiving, food cards with dollar totals, gift cards with dollar totals.
- One **Print this page** button — made for handing to the Board. A season picker looks back at past years for the audit.
- Nothing to maintain: every number is recalculated from the live records each time the page opens.

6.8 Adoptions

- Every family adopted out this season — family, town, pickup number, who adopted them, contact person, phone, and mailing address. A count up top, a season picker for past years, and one **Print this page** button.
- This is the letters list: print it when asking last year's adopters whether they wish to adopt again. Families are added here by marking them adopted on their application (section 6.3); roughly 50-60 families a season go through the adoption program.
- The Season summary also shows "Of the families served, adopted out: N."

6.9 Paper application (PDF)

- Upload this year's *blank* printable applications — TWO slots now: the Family application and the Elderly/Disabled application, the files families download to fill out by hand. One button each; the new file replaces the old immediately. Until a file is uploaded, its public link shows a kind "call the message line" note instead.
- Not to be confused with *Enter a paper application* (6.4), which is for typing in a *completed* paper form.

6.10 Donors

- The donor list: search, add, open a donor to record what they gave (date, amount, or item). The year's total shows at the top, with a year control for past years. Deletes ask first and offer Undo.

6.11 Messages

- Notes families send through the public Contact form. Mark read, delete, or reply (reply opens your email program). The same messages also arrive in the program's email inbox.

7. Privacy duties

- Applications hold sensitive information about low-income families and their children. It is used for this program only. Share lists only with the people who need them — packers, distributors, the county audit, and (with the family's recorded permission) adoption partners.
- Sign in only on a computer you trust; sign out on shared or public ones.
- The packing slips volunteers use deliberately leave off income, good deeds, the parentage note, and the coordinator's private notes — volunteers see only what packing needs; the Gifts-to-pack column is the coordinator's curated list, not raw family data (the **Packing note** field is the one deliberate exception: it exists to speak to packers, and its label says so). Collect printed slips and lists after packing day; don't leave them lying around.
- Every delete in the admin — applications, household members, jobs, donors, messages, pickup days — asks for confirmation and offers an Undo button right after. You cannot lose a record with one slip of the mouse.

8. When to call the developer

The website is built to run a whole season with no technical help. These are the exceptions — they are quick for a developer and not possible from the admin screens:

- **Adding or removing a coordinator's sign-in email** (the first task in any handover).
- **Adding a new town** (with its number block and card color).
- Changing the questions on the application form itself, or the wording of the public pages that isn't covered by "This year's news."
- Anything that looks broken. Note what you clicked, what you expected, and what happened — nothing you can click will damage the data.
- Season records are deliberately kept, never purged — the county audit relies on them (owner decision, July 2026). If the Board ever wants very old seasons cleared, that is a developer task on explicit request.

Developer contact: Cody Schluez · 425-765-7609 · codydps@gmail.com

Not developer tasks (you do these yourself, no help needed): all news and schedule content, the paper PDF upload, the card tallies, and everything in section 6.

9. What this manual does not cover

This is the *website* manual. The program is bigger than the website, and that knowledge lives elsewhere:

- **The program training manual** (written by the longtime coordinator) — the adoption program (~45 family adoptions a season), eligibility background, board and volunteer meetings, donor and adoption letters, referral forms to daycares and schools, coordination with the county's other holiday programs, and county finance procedures.
- **The fallbacks that must never disappear:** the message phone line (608-723-2136 ext 1194) and the paper application. Some applicants cannot or will not use a website; the program serves them all the same.
- **Key facts:** mailing address 245 W. Elm St., Lancaster WI 53813 · program email skleinow@co.grant.wi.gov · donation drop-offs at Allegiant Oil (Platteville and Lancaster) · checks payable to the project.

Grant County Holiday Project — Website Operations Manual · written July 2026, matching the website as deployed that month · website by Cody Schluez.